



THE LITTLE REWRITES

THE GIRL WHO LOVED GRAY

A picture book about all the colors between yes and no.

MK PARRISH



YES

NO

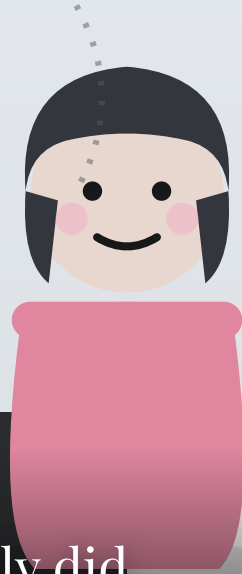
The world, they told her, comes in two colors.

Black. And white.

Yes or no. Good or bad.

Pick a side, they said.

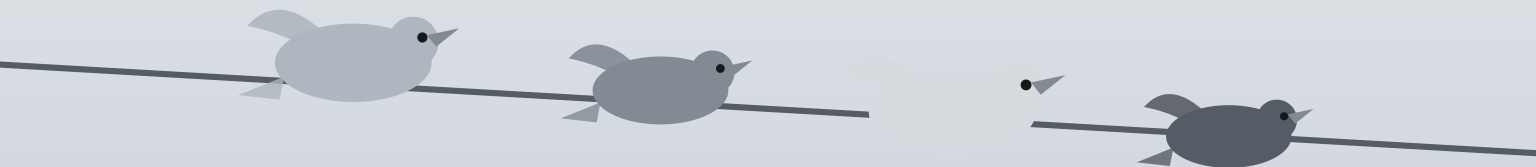
Quick.



Marlowe tried. She truly did.
But on the hard white line,
with the hard black line beside it,
something in her pulled tight and small —
like a shoe on the wrong foot.



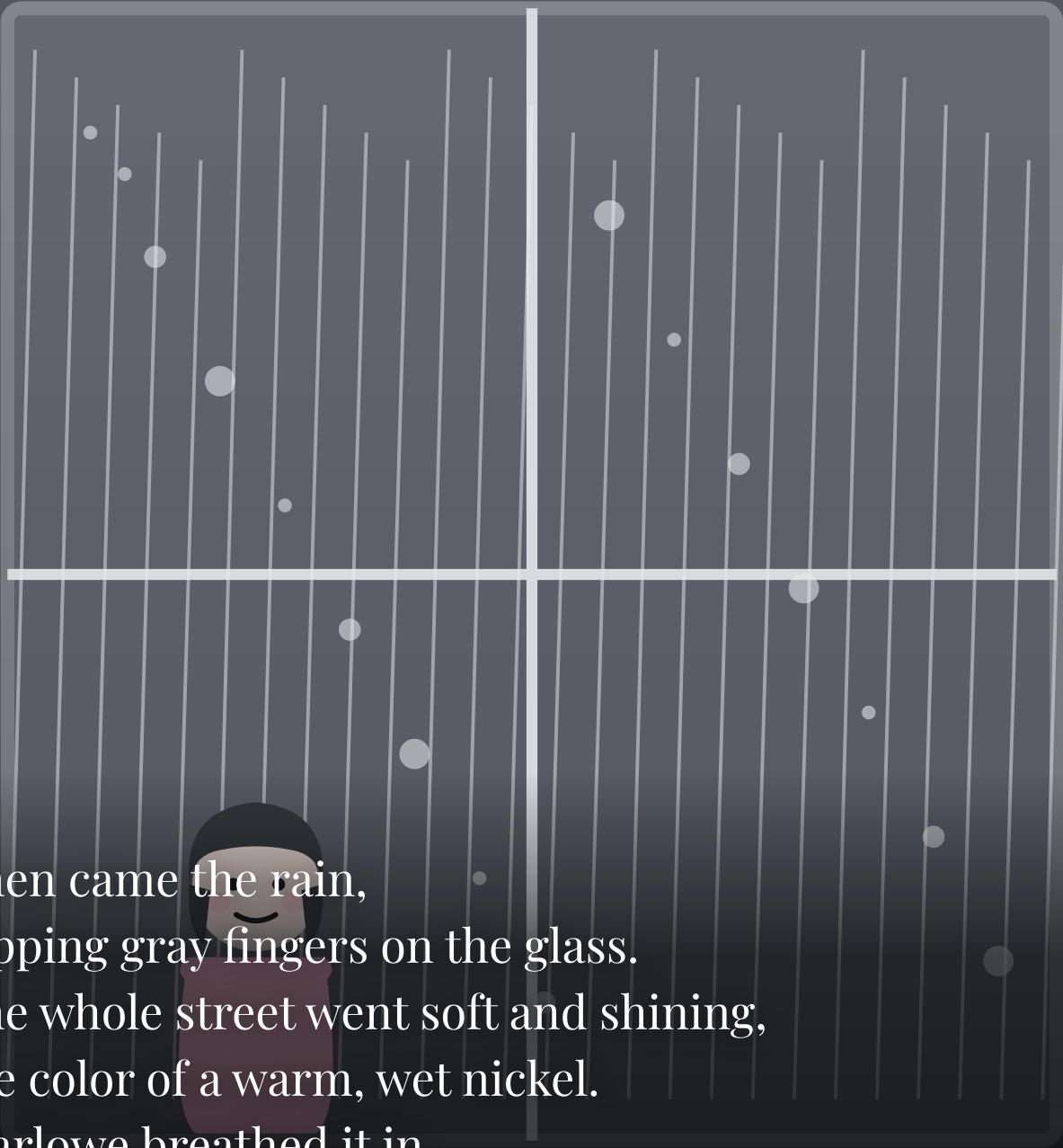
Then, one gray morning, the fog came.
It rolled down the hills like a slow, soft breath
and swallowed every sharp edge in the world.
Marlowe stepped inside it.
The fog held her like a secret.



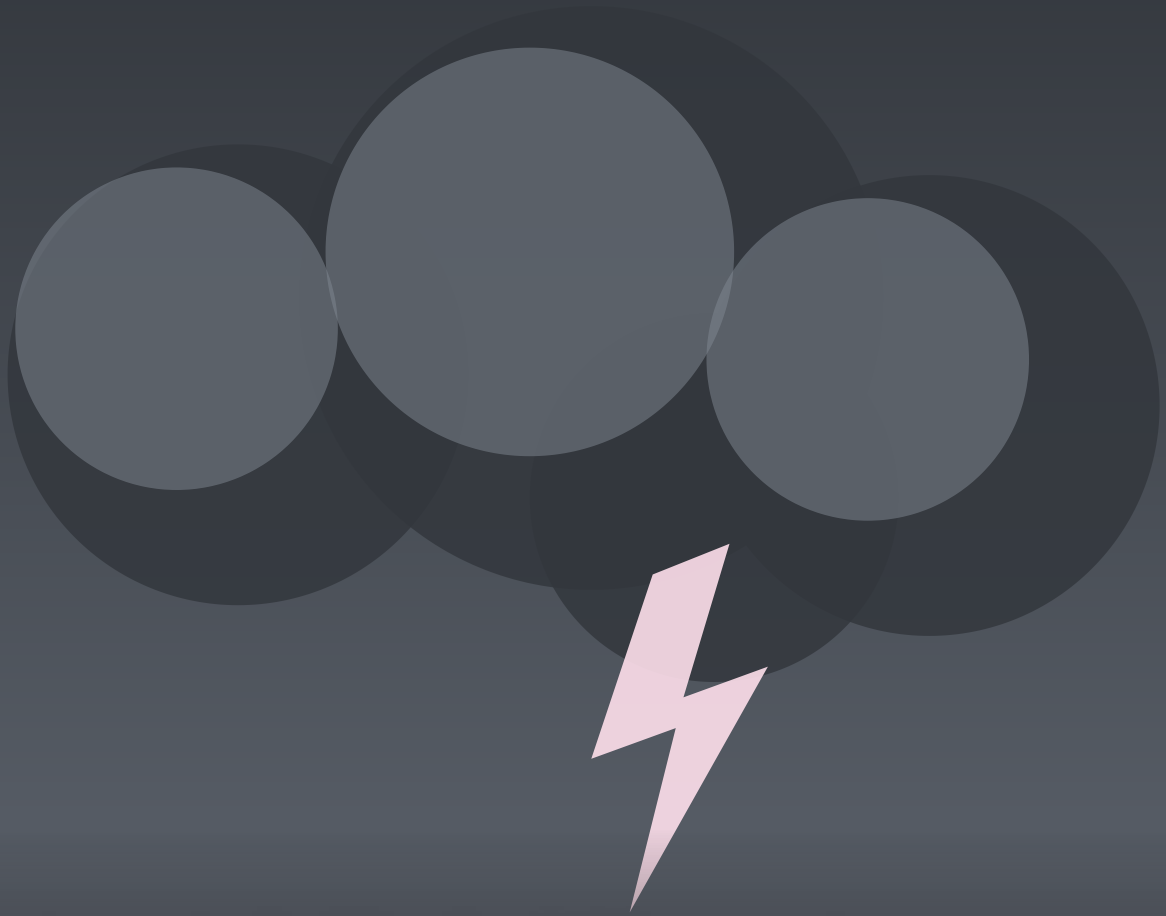
And there, in the fog, she found gray.
Not one gray.

Hundreds.

Dove gray. Smoke gray. Old-spoon silver.
The hush of gray inside a pigeon's wing.

An illustration of a person with dark hair and a purple shirt looking out a window. The window is covered in rain, represented by vertical white lines and gray dots of varying sizes. A white crosshair is centered on the window. The text is overlaid on the bottom left of the window.

Then came the rain,
tapping gray fingers on the glass.
The whole street went soft and shining,
the color of a warm, wet nickel.
Marlowe breathed it in.

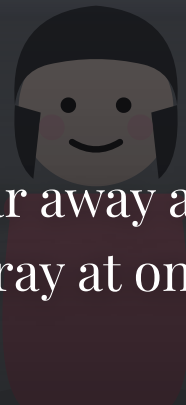


A storm stacked its clouds like gray stone plates.

Not scary.

Enormous. Alive.

Thunder turned over, far away and gentle —
and the sky was every gray at once.



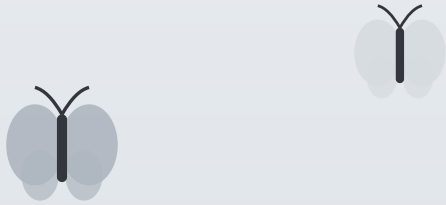


And at the very end of the day,
she found the best gray of all.

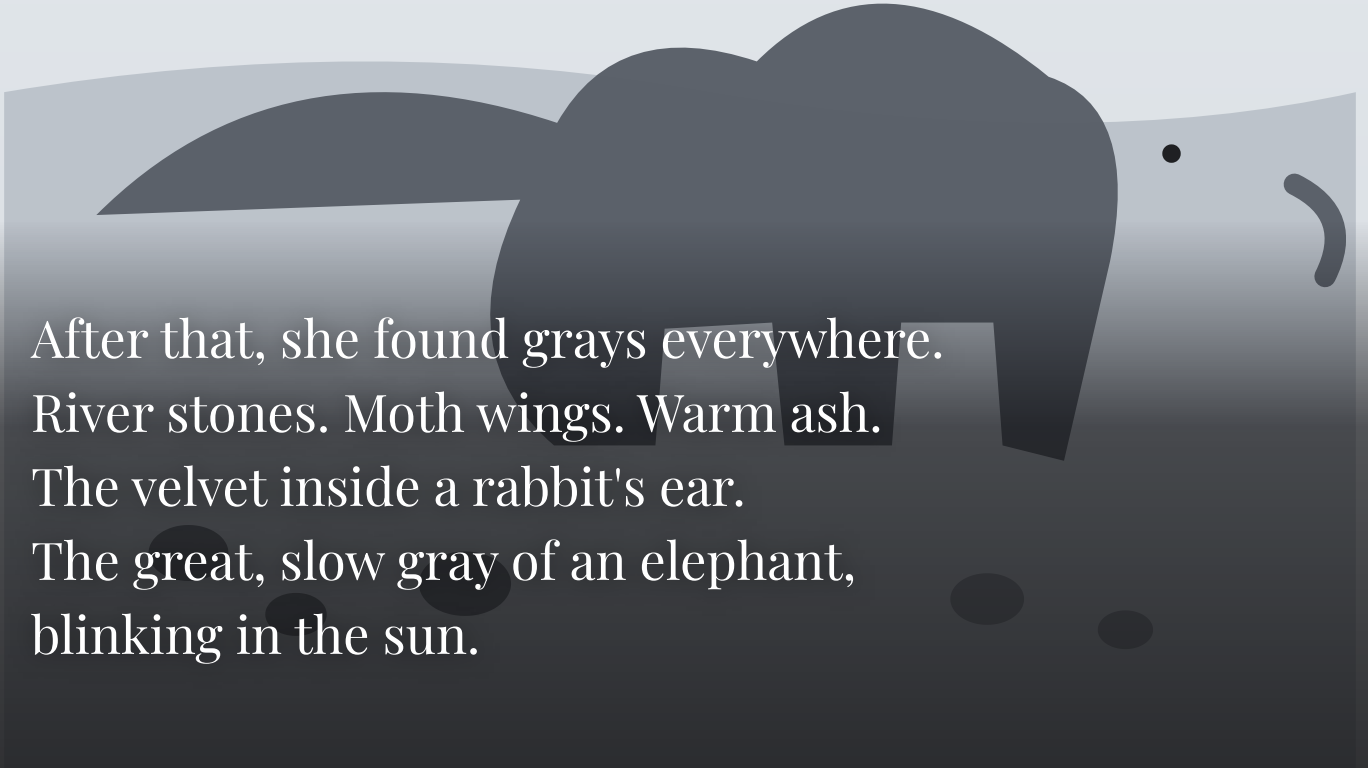
Twilight.

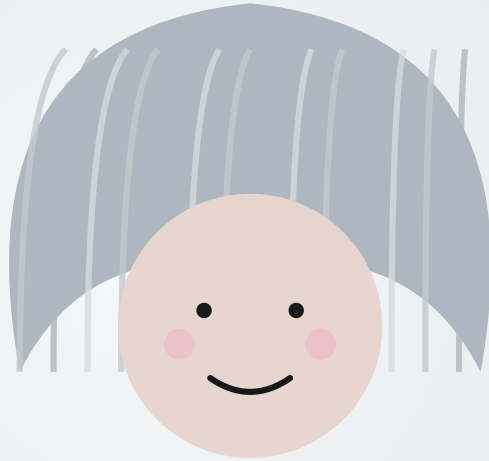
Not day. Not night.

The hour the whole world holds its breath
and is lovely in the holding.



After that, she found grays everywhere.
River stones. Moth wings. Warm ash.
The velvet inside a rabbit's ear.
The great, slow gray of an elephant,
blinking in the sun.



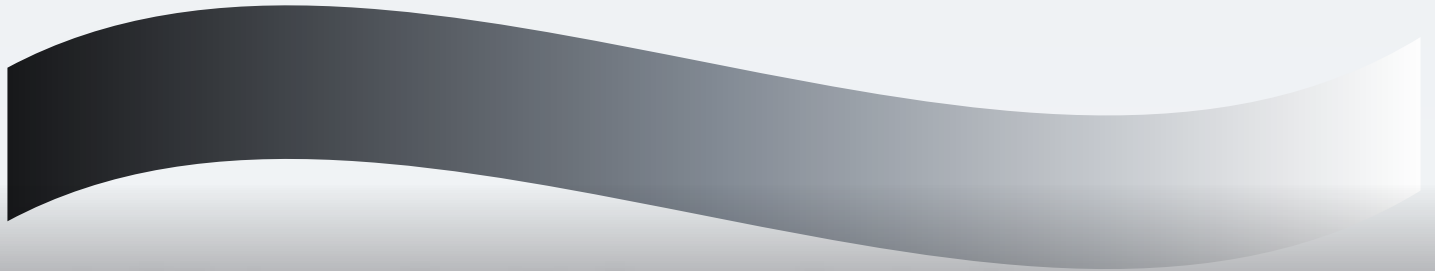


And her grandmother's hair —
silver and smoke and moonlight,
a whole long life of grays.
Every strand a story
that was never all happy,
and never all sad.



BLACK

WHITE



And that was when Marlowe understood.
Black and white
are only the two far ends
of one long, soft ribbon.
Everything that matters
lives in the gray in between.





So she stopped picking sides so fast.
She learned to say, "I'm not sure yet,"
and mean it like a door swinging open.
She learned to love the questions
that don't have quick answers.



The world is not black and white, little one,
no matter who says it is.
It is dove and pewter,
smoke and silver,
storm and twilight.
It is gray —
and gray is where the whole true world lives.
Go on. Go love it.

FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

We hand children a black-and-white world early: right and wrong, smart and dumb, winner and loser, us and them. It is faster to think that way, and lonelier, and mostly untrue. This book is a small argument for the gray — for nuance, for "it depends," for holding two true things at once, for the patience to stay in a question a little longer.

When you finish, look for a gray together. A pigeon. A rain cloud. The soft middle of an argument that isn't all one person's fault. Then say the sentence that undoes a lifetime of hard lines: *"Two things can be true at the same time."*